

Online Resource 1

From Ethical Entitlement to Institutional Protection: Hospital Visitation and Reimbursement Governance in Japan

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Caption: Source manifest, Japanese-primary-source translation table, and data sources for the institutional coverage analysis.

Part A. Primary-Source Manifest

This section identifies the principal Japanese primary sources supporting the manuscript's institutional and legal analysis. For Japanese statutes and administrative materials, the current Japanese text is controlling. English translations below are authors' translations unless otherwise stated.

A1. FY2026 medical fee revision: hospital visitation provisions

Issuing body: Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare (MHLW)

Explanatory source: 令和 8 年度診療報酬改定 II – 2 – 2 円滑な入退院の実現－①, p. 71

Official URL: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/content/12400000/001680923.pdf>

Implementing notification cited in manuscript: 保医発 0305 第 7 号 (5 March 2026), corrected version

Implementing-notification URL: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/content/12400000/001732097.pdf>

Add-on-specific value statement (Japanese): 「入院中の患者とその家族等との面会は、患者の尊厳の保持及び療養生活の質の向上に資するのみならず、円滑な退院支援を行う上でも重要であることから、」

Authors' translation: “Visitation between hospitalised patients and family members and others contributes not only to preserving patient dignity and improving quality of life during treatment, but is also important for facilitating smooth discharge support.”

General provision (Japanese): 「入院中の患者への家族等による面会については、感染対策等の正当な理由なく面会を妨げないよう、面会に係る規定を策定する等の配慮をすることが望ましい。」

Authors' translation: “With respect to visits to hospitalised patients by family members and others, hospitals are encouraged to take measures, such as establishing visitation rules, so that visitation is not impeded without legitimate reasons, including infection-control considerations.”

Translation note: The phrase 「望ましい」 is hortatory. The stronger add-on-specific provision uses 「妨げてはならない」 and separately requires care that unavoidable restrictions are not more stringent than necessary, written rules, periodic review, and visible communication.

Add-on-specific provision (Japanese, relevant excerpt): 「感染対策等の正当な理由なく、入院中の患者に対する家族等による面会を妨げてはならないこと。また、やむを得ず面会の制限を行う場合であっても、当該制限が必要以上に厳格なものとならないよう配慮すること。」

Authors' translation: “Hospitals must not impede visits by family members and others to hospitalised patients without a legitimate reason, including infection-control considerations. Where restrictions are unavoidable, hospitals must take care not to make them more stringent than necessary.”

Add-on-specific rule-making, review and communication requirement (Japanese): 「なお、これらを踏まえ、面会に関する規定を策定するとともに、当該規定について定期的に見直しを行うこと。併せて、患者及びその家族等に対し、当該規定の内容が十分に周知されるよう、病棟等の見やすい場所に掲示すること。」

Authors' translation: “Hospitals must also establish visitation rules, review those rules periodically, and ensure that patients and family members and others are adequately informed of them through visible posting in wards or other suitable locations.”

A2. Mental Health and Welfare Act: request for discharge or improvement in treatment

Source: Act on Mental Health and Welfare for Persons with Mental Disorders (Act No. 123 of 1950), arts. 38-4 and 38-5

Japanese source: <https://laws.e-gov.go.jp/law/325AC0100000123>

Government English reference translation: <https://www.japaneselawtranslation.go.jp/en/laws/view/4235/en>

Scope: Article 38-4 provides a route for an inpatient or qualifying family member to request discharge or improvement in treatment; Article 38-5 requires the prefectural governor to refer such a request to the Psychiatric Review Board. These provisions are not a visitation-specific appeal mechanism.

A3. Psychiatric treatment standards: communication and visitation

Issuing body: Ministry of Health and Welfare / Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare

Source: Notification No. 130 of 8 April 1988, Second: Communication and Visitation

Official URL: https://www.mhlw.go.jp/web/t_doc?dataId=80136000&dataType=0&pageNo=1

Japanese: 「精神科病院入院患者の院外にある者との通信及び来院者との面会…は…医療上も重要な意義を有するとともに、患者の人権の観点からも重要な意義を有するものであり、原則として自由に行われることが必要である。」

Authors' translation: “Communication by psychiatric inpatients with persons outside the hospital and visits from persons coming to the hospital are of important medical and human-rights significance and should, in principle, be freely permitted.”

Restriction standard: The standards permit restrictions only within the limits indispensable for care or protection, on reasonable grounds, by reasonable methods and within a reasonable scope, following careful assessment of the individual patient's need. They also address recording and communicating the restriction and its reasons.

A4. Psychiatric Review Board Operational Manual

Current full manual: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/content/001501540.pdf>

Revision notice cited in manuscript bibliography: Notification No. 1127-5 of 27 November 2023, effective 1 April 2024

Revision-notice URL: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/content/001172523.pdf>

Relevant institutional feature: The manual provides that administrative work relating to Psychiatric Review Board review is to be handled by the Mental Health and Welfare Center rather than the prefectural mental-health welfare division in order to further secure objectivity and independence. This describes institutional design and does not establish empirical effectiveness or timeliness.

A5. Medical Safety Support Centre Operational Guidelines

Issuing body: Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare

Source: Medical Safety Support Centre Operational Guidelines, final revision 31 March 2026

Official URL: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/content/10800000/001685657.pdf>

Relevant institutional feature: The guidelines position centres as neutral consultation and coordination infrastructure between patients/residents and healthcare institutions. They do not determine negligence, causation, or responsibility and are not binding adjudicators.

Part B. Japanese Primary-Source Translation Table

B1. FY2026 reimbursement - general inpatient provision

Japanese: 「入院中の患者への家族等による面会については、感染対策等の正当な理由なく面会を妨げないよう、面会に係る規定を策定する等の配慮をすることが望ましい。」

English: With respect to visits to hospitalised patients by family members and others, hospitals are encouraged to take measures, such as establishing visitation rules, so that visitation is not impeded without legitimate reasons, including infection-control considerations.

Source/translation note: MHLW FY2026 medical fee revision, p. 71. Authors' translation; 「望ましい」 is hortatory.

B2. FY2026 reimbursement - Discharge Support Add-ons 1-3

Japanese: 「感染対策等の正当な理由なく、入院中の患者に対する家族等による面会を妨げてはならないこと。」

English: Hospitals must not impede visits by family members and others to hospitalised patients without a legitimate reason, including infection-control considerations.

Source/translation note: MHLW FY2026 medical fee revision, p. 71. Authors' translation.

B2a. FY2026 reimbursement - dignity and quality-of-life value statement

Japanese: 「入院中の患者とその家族等との面会は、患者の尊厳の保持及び療養生活の質の向上に資するのみならず、円滑な退院支援を行う上でも重要であることから、」

English: Visitation between hospitalised patients and family members and others contributes not only to preserving patient dignity and improving quality of life during treatment, but is also important for facilitating smooth discharge support.

Source/translation note: MHLW FY2026 medical fee revision, p. 71. Authors' translation. This value statement belongs to the add-on-specific provision.

B2b. FY2026 reimbursement - written rules, periodic review and visible communication

Japanese: 「なお、これらを踏まえ、面会に関する規定を策定するとともに、当該規定について定期的に見直しを行うこと。併せて、患者及びその家族等に対し、当該規定の内容が十分に周知されるよう、病棟等の見やすい場所に掲示すること。」

English: Hospitals must also establish visitation rules, review those rules periodically, and ensure that patients and family members and others are adequately informed of them through visible posting in wards or other suitable locations.

Source/translation note: MHLW FY2026 medical fee revision, p. 71. Authors' translation.

B3. FY2026 reimbursement - restriction intensity

Japanese: 「また、やむを得ず面会の制限を行う場合であっても、当該制限が必要以上に厳格なものとならないよう配慮すること。」

English: Where restrictions are unavoidable, hospitals must take care not to make them more stringent than necessary.

Source/translation note: MHLW FY2026 medical fee revision, p. 71. Authors' translation.

B4. Psychiatric treatment standards - default freedom

Japanese: 「精神科病院入院患者の院外にある者との通信及び来院者との面会…は…医療上も重要な意義を有するとともに、患者の人権の観点からも重要な意義を有するものであり、原則として自由に行われることが必要である。」

English: Communication by psychiatric inpatients with persons outside the hospital and visits from persons coming to the hospital are of important medical and human-rights significance and should, in principle, be freely permitted.

Source/translation note: MHLW Notification No. 130 of 8 April 1988. Authors' translation.

B5. Psychiatric treatment standards - grounds and scope of restriction

Japanese: 「電話及び面会に関しては患者の医療又は保護に欠くことのできない限度での制限が行われる場合があるが、これは…医療又は保護の上で合理的な理由がある場合であって、かつ、合理的な方法及び範囲における制限に限られるものであり、個々の患者の医療又は保護の上での必要性を慎重に判断して決定すべきものである。」

English: Restrictions on telephone use and visitation may be imposed only to the extent indispensable for the patient's medical care or protection, where there are reasonable grounds relating to care or protection, and only by reasonable methods and within a reasonable scope; the necessity for the individual patient should be carefully assessed before a decision is made.

Source/translation note: MHLW Notification No. 130 of 8 April 1988. Authors' translation.

B6. Mental Health and Welfare Act, Article 38-4 - request for discharge or improvement in treatment

Japanese: 「精神科病院に入院中の者又はその家族等…は、厚生労働省令で定めるところにより、都道府県知事に対し、当該入院中の者を退院させ、又は精神科病院の管理者に対し、その者を退院させることを命じ、若しくはその者の処遇の改善のために必要な措置を採ることを命じることを求めることができる。」

English: An inpatient of a psychiatric hospital or a qualifying family member may request the prefectural governor to discharge the inpatient, or to order the hospital administrator to discharge the inpatient or to take measures necessary to improve the inpatient's treatment.

Source/translation note: Authors' concise translation of the operative point; the current Japanese statute controls. A government English reference translation is available from Japanese Law Translation.

B7. Psychiatric Review Board - independence architecture

Japanese: 「審査の客観性、独立性の一層の確保を図るため…審査会の審査に関する都道府県知事の事務は…精神保健福祉主管部局ではなく精神保健福祉センターにおいて行うものとする。」

English: To further secure the objectivity and independence of review, administrative work relating to Psychiatric Review Board review is to be carried out by the Mental Health and Welfare Center rather than by the prefectural mental-health welfare division.

Source/translation note: Psychiatric Review Board Operational Manual. Authors' translation.

B8. Medical Safety Support Centre - neutrality and non-adjudicatory role

Japanese: 「患者・住民と医療提供施設との間にあって、中立的な立場から相談等に対応し…」／「センターは、医療行為における過失や因果関係の有無、責任の所在を判断・決定するのではなく…中立的な立場から問題解決に向けた双方の取組みを支援するよう努める。」

English: Centres respond to consultations from a neutral position between patients/residents and healthcare institutions and seek to support both sides' efforts toward problem resolution. They do not determine whether negligence or causation exists or determine responsibility.

Source/translation note: MHLW Medical Safety Support Centre Operational Guidelines, final revision 31 March 2026. Authors' translation.

Part C. Data Sources for the Institutional Coverage Analysis

The numerator was derived from official facility-standard notification registers published by Japan's seven Regional Bureaus of Health and Welfare and the Shikoku Branch Office. The analysis used medical-institution register snapshots dated 1 July or 1 August 2026. The live webpages are updated periodically and may now display later monthly snapshots; the table records the analytical snapshot date used for each jurisdictional source.

Bureau / office	Official access page	Analytical snapshot used	Register note
Hokkaido Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/hokkaido/gyomu/gyomu/hoken_kikan/todokede_komokubetsu.html	1 July 2026	Item-specific register; includes A246 (Discharge Support Add-on).

Bureau / office	Official access page	Analytical snapshot used	Register note
Tohoku Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/tohoku/gyomu/gyomu/hoken_kikan/kijun_jurijoukyou.html	1 August 2026	Official facility-standard receipt-status access page for the six Tohoku prefectures.
Kanto-Shinetsu Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/kantoshinetsu/chousa/kijyun.html	1 August 2026	Full and item-specific facility-standard registers.
Tokai-Hokuriku Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/tokaihokuriku/newpage_00350.html	1 August 2026	Item-specific facility-standard registers.
Kinki Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/kinki/gyomu/gyomu/hoken_kikan/shitei_jokyo_00004.html	1 August 2026	Official facility-standard receipt-status registers for the Kinki jurisdiction.
Chugoku-Shikoku Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/chugokushikoku/chousaka/shisetsukijunjuri.html	1 August 2026	Full facility-standard registers for the five Chugoku prefectures (Tottori, Shimane, Okayama, Hiroshima, and Yamaguchi).
Shikoku Branch Office	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/shikoku/gyomu/gyomu/hoken_kikan/shitei/	1 August 2026	Full facility-standard receipt-status registers for Kagawa, Tokushima, Ehime, and Kochi.
Kyushu Regional Bureau of Health and Welfare	https://kouseikyoku.mhlw.go.jp/kyushu/gyomu/gyomu/hoken_kikan/index_00007.html	1 August 2026	Full facility-standard receipt-status registers for the Kyushu bureau jurisdictions.

Snapshot-date note: The dates above are the analytical snapshots used in the coverage dataset. Because the official access pages are live and updated monthly, the pages may display a later snapshot when accessed after the analysis date.

C2. National denominator

Source: Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, Dynamic Survey of Medical Institutions: preliminary figures as of the end of May 2026.

Official URL: <https://www.mhlw.go.jp/toukei/saikin/hw/iryosd/m26/dl/is2605.pdf>

Use in analysis: The official national denominator was 7,949 hospitals. The derived classification dataset contained 7,955 hospitals. Size-specific denominators therefore sum to 7,955 and are descriptive within that derived dataset; they are not an alternative national denominator.

Translation and Source Control Note

For Japanese primary sources, the current Japanese text is controlling. Government English is used as a reference translation where available. Authors' translations are intended to preserve the normative force of the Japanese wording. The live Regional Bureau webpages are periodically updated; the manuscript's analysis refers to the July/August 2026 snapshots used during data extraction.